

A TILTED FIELD

Christopher James Ferguson

DEDICATION

I'd like to dedicate this book to William Spaniel for expanding my views on international relationships, internal relationships, and lines, as well as feral historian for introducing to a wide verity of books and ideas revolving around technology and the state, and how it effects man.

Thank you.

This is the rough draft of A TILTED FIELD, it is not intended to be the final piece of this book, and should not be treated as such.

A CHOICE THAT DOESN'T EXIST

MELDOA

Meldoa got into the car reading through the endless paperwork of profit margins and facility productivity sheets, shes tends to make a habit of going around checking up on each location to verify there reports, some of her sisters and brothers hate her for this but she adamant about the accuracy of her books, as well as protecting her fathers investments.

Her first stop was one of her brothers districts he was the one responsible for arms shipments both in and out of the city and by nature of the business, everything required a certain amount of extra

care when it came to ensuring everything was running smoothly. In fact one of the reasons father put this bother in charge of this operation was because he was reasonable, trustworthy and in good relations with Meldoa.

"Ah, nice seeing you again sister." Denna (Meldoa's bother) said as she stepped into his office, the rough oak floor and dusty interior making her nose tickle. "May I see your internal paperwork." She asked, never the one for pleasantries instead favoring bluntness one of the many reasons where she is today, however every blunt object has there edge.

"Yes, yes I already have them right here," Denna then plopped a mound of paper onto his desk. "I assume you also want a tour," He said wrapping up the paperwork with

a thick piece of linen thread,
Meldoa nodded her head.

The tour did not last long as it was only the warehouse, meeting locations would always be switched, and it would be odd for a family accountant to be at a place where supposedly nothing was supposed to be delivered, and the state mostly handled there own shipments so there was no need for that either.

"Anything else you'd like to see." He asked as they reached the entrance, there where only minor discrepancies many of which could be chocked up to errors, or changes in season. She shook her head, "no that will be all see you next quarter," she then left and returned to her car. "Hena's next," Meldoa said, her driver nodded, starting the car and putting it in gear.

Meldoa had 25 siblings many of which were still young and didn't command enough respect to be able to hold their own district, or business, only 11 had reached such a point, and she couldn't possibly do these 11 in a single day so she did it by priority, Denna was always the first due to the sensitive nature of the business, whilst everyone else usually got on top because of large discrepancies or recent events that compelled an early visit.

It wasn't long until she found herself at one of Hena's warehouses, a warehouse that was the location of a rather grueling crane accident that left a few people dead and one injured, at least that was what she remembered when the report got to her desk, in all honestly she didn't care much

for the people they where all apes anyways, what she did care about was the cargo listed on the manifest.

Expensive jewelry some of which where damaged beyond repair, one and a half tons of flour that was lost to the harbor, as well as a bunch of other miscellaneous products which where damaged.

She stepped into her sisters office, her child jumping off of a seat that was in the corner of the room. "Auntie!" She yelled, whilst Meldoa was by all means cold, she wasn't one to neglect a child in fact she has spent many hours caring for her sisters and brothers children effectively acting like a nanny however she did not posses any of her own.

She wasn't unable to do so, her

instrument was still apart of her and functioned as expected but unfortunately for her father lacked any such will to put that instrument to use, her sisters have speculated she's too self centered to think of such things, or to care but they had failed to consider that she just wasn't interested at the moment.

She picked up the child and brought her niece into her arms. "How are you doing Francis?" Meldoa asked, Meldoa had always been a hypocrite when it came to youth in the terms of small talk perhaps she knew more to motherhood then interacting properly with her other wolfkin. "I'm doing great, I learnt bigger words." Meldoa smiled, which if one had saw would probably see them drop dead from shock, "Learned, dear."

"Learned." The little pea respond her ears perking up to the ceiling, an easily excited little learner, "yes, dear, L-E-A-R-N with an E-D at the end."

"Ooohh."

"Now, dear where might I find your mother."

"Oh, she said she would be in the, ugghh, you know place with all the big boxs."

"The floor?" Meldoa asked.

"Yeah, yeah." Francis immediately responded. Meldoa held the child more firmly "Well lets go get here then." The child started giggling excited to be able to wander about with her aunt they walked for some time, until they came across a section which housed Hena, they both immediately locked eyes, the sister immediately

possessing an expression of annoyance.

"Let me guess, quarterly checkup," Meldoa nodded, and then her sister exhaled. "Come, I'll do the tour and then get you your documents, and I'll also assume you want to talk about the crane accident." Hena then turned around and Meldoa followed.

"Have you handled the reimbursements," Meldoa asked. "Yes, yes we've also taken care of procedure to ensure that it never happens again." Meldoa nodded albeit a little skeptically, her sister is well known to her to care about time more than about quality and these accidents have happened in the past because of this mentality. "May I ask what changes." Her sister looked back at her, Hena knew she couldn't blame

her for the suspicion.

"We've changed the ropes for chains, we also do inspections every week, to make sure that there properly fit for use." Hearing direct names to solutions put Meldoa at ease hopefully she finally reaching the point where she's recognizing speed is not always fast.

Hena then lead Meldoa through the warehouse things, could obviously be better but the most glaring issue was the sagging wood beam in the back corning, in fact such issue was starting to become noticeable on the outside of the warehouse as the weight of the create was starting to push out the brick wall but only slightly for now.

"And here's your paperwork."

Hena said placing the stack onto the table not even bothering to tie it. "Auntie, auntie, can I go over to your place." The little pea excitedly said, "that's all up to your mother dear," She then looked at Hena with pleading eyes, "fine do as you wish." Meldona, then grabbed the stack of paper placing it tightly underneath her arm, as she carried the little pea out of the out of the brick building, and into the car.

"Hello, miss Francis," the driver said with a smile, brightening up his day. "Hey," she responded as she found her seat, energetically bouncing her feet off of the end. It wasn't hard for Meldoa to find time for the children, all here responsibility's could be mostly dealt with in one place that being her manor, in fact

she rarely left such a place due to that fact, which invoked a constant prodding voice into her mind, that being one that belong to her father.

Meldona has been a virgin from birth, and has never married, instead paying more attention to her study's, which lead her to becoming the familys accountant, and now due to her role and her fathers increasing preface and reliance on her to ensure the smooth running of there businesses, would like to see her bring children into the family. In recent years his pestering had gone from somewhat tolerable to down right harassment, right to the point of luring her into blind dates and even recommending the injection of semen into her womb, all methods, and potential partners she firmly

rejected.

Although she knew he was coming out of a place of business and fatherly duty she was starting to run out of patience, and her annoyance was on a fast track to hostility, She pondered of what to do, she understood that she could just ignore him, as he had never disrespected his children's agency but she also just wanted him to stop and be quiet on the ordeal.

She thought a little longer until she decided that it would be a good idea to shelve it until she was alone and didn't have a child in tow. "I think we'll call it a day for now bring me to fathers house." Meldoa said beginning a comb through the documents before her. "I thought we where going to your house," Meldoa smiled. "We will dear, I just need to talk to

your grandfather first." Her eyes opened up, "oh, grandpa's house I thought we where going to someone else's." Francis always had trouble with remembering the significant of certain words, her mind, and sometimes it felt like she only took part of a sentence in at a time.

"My father is your grandfather," Meldoa immediately tried to teach, "your father is my grandfather... How does that work." Meldoa smiled at the excited little pea, "when I was born, I was born under your grandfather, which makes him my father, as I was born under him, and since your mother, which is my sister, was also born under him, when you where born made my father your grandfather." Meldoa went as slow she could letting the child digest what was being spoken.

"Oh." the pea said. "imagine it like a tree that's grown upside down, each branch is a separate person adding to the whole tree." The child's eyes practically popped out of her head. "Oh, so that means lisa is your sister too."

"Yes, dear."

"And Semosa is your brother, and Tela is your mother." She caught on quick, Meldoa thought to herself, happy over the fact that she was able to grasp something new about the world so quickly. "Yes, dear." Meldoa repeated. "Oh, that's why you guys all act weird around each other," Meldoa couldn't help but laugh a little, but what the child said isn't wrong from her perspective as to her they do act different when around each other especially with Meldoa as she is the favored child. "I wish mommy

would teach me more," the child spoke, Meldoa sorta nodded trying to remain natural in her expression.

The little pea was by no means neglected but, children require special attention always, and if that attention is not met it tends to harbor similar feelings of neglect. Meldoa knew it was for the most part her sisters fault for not being more attentive to the child's feelings and time. Her sister always had this knack for getting things done as quickly as possible in every aspect of her life.

It wasn't long before they found themselves at fathers manor, the white granite building towing over all the little shops and residences that laid beyond it's steel gates. Some would say it was an odd place for a manor, but this

residence had been built long ago when this was once field.

They pulled up to the front gate, one of the family's men coming to it, immediately recognizing the vehicle as he did, he opened the gate waving them through and the driver did as instructed, pulling up to the front of the building it's ornately carved door not even gaining a grain of attention from Meldoa who's become all too familiar with the sight, while Francis became infatuated with it's precise carvings upon crossing it each time.

They both entered into the man hall the child running about checking everything there was to see from the paintings to the walls, down to the tiny little ornaments on the railings, Meldoa

continued up the stairs whilst the child stared with glistening eyes at all these things, smiling as she did, and once she reached the top she gently called out Francis's name and she came running.

Meldoa understood the child wanted to see more, as she once did when she was with the litter, but she couldn't let her out of her sight, even in the safety of one of her family's buildings.

Francis hardly gets to see her uncle and only has saw him during family's gatherings and the occasional visit, he was nothing short of an enigma to her, he was quiet and had a look to him that told you he was a man who barely kept a quiet mind, with this the child coined her uncle the nickname strange old man, she was wise enough to never speak this with

anyone but herself.

The two then made it too his study, a place he spent much time in, a place where he's made plenty of decisions. They stepped through the double doors and where greeted my incense, Meldoa's father was sometimes anxious when it came to certain matters, he used incense and tea to help stave out rampant anxiety something that he has noted effects his thinking, something was obviously bothering his mind.

Meldoa and Francis then became seated, father only acknowledging there presence for a moment before writing down in that moment what he was thinking. "Welcome, Meldoa and I see you brought a little one." Meldoa nodded, "and I assume your here updateing me on alls the goings on." She nodded once more. "I've only attended to the major

concerns of this quarter, yours truly and my sister Hena,"

"Ah yes, Hena and I assume everything is alright with Denna."

"Yes, Denna business looks to be running well, I have yet to look over the documents but I see nothing different in my years overseeing him."

Father nodding his head pleased by the consistency and predictability that these two operate on, there good children and he wishes them well.

"However, Hena's has made an effort in improving the main warehouse on the port river."

The father widened his eyes a little, "you mean I didn't have to do anything."

"Not in this instance no, that being said there is a sagging beam,

and a pallet of cargo is currently pushing out the wall on the third floor, she made no comment and actively looked away when I brought my eyes to it."

Father exhaled, "just when I was getting hope... That's not something I can overlook, losing a warehouse especially now, will not be ideal, I'll hire a crew from Deshane, have them clean up another up and coming mess." Father then swore under his breath, making sure the child could not hear.

"Anything else." Meldoa shook her head, "those where the only two I could get to for today I intend to visit the rest in the following days." Father seemed to shift in his chair uneasily. "Make sure there quick, things are getting uncomfortable, with the Terina family." Meldoa cocked her eyebrow.

"Another war," father leaned forward a bit, thinking, "maybe," "I suppose then I should take my leave." Meldoa then proceeded to rise. "Come, Francis it's time to go to my residence." The child, jumped off the couch, and ran to the door waiting for Meldoa to open it.

"Meldoa, before you go any developments on a husband, I know a few men who are interested," at this moment Meldoa decided she had, had it with her fathers continued assault on her marriage status, but she wasn't going to take it out on him here, no, no, she's much too clever and much too willing for such an uncouth display. "I'm working on it father." Meldoa said as she hurried out the door with the little one in tow, in fact she already went over this plan long

ago.

Her and the little one both got into the car, as Meldoa went over the details of her plan in her head once more, to marry a fellow wolfkin would send the wrong message it would mean I'd be serious about becoming a wife and bearing children, and it would just ramp up my fathers assault however an ape makes the perfect threat, perfectly taboo to the point where people are disgusted by it, she thought to herself, while a mischievous grin began to take form, the perfect threat. All that she has to do is go about this carefully.

They soon arrived at Meldoa's manor, a large gated house just outside the city limits, it's land was small in comparison to some of the manors she had been to but

nonetheless to any common folk it was still vast, the child rushed inside with Meldoa right behind, both having separate reasons as to why there rushing ahead.

Meldoa tended to the child all night, ensure her time wasn't wasted, she learned, played, and ate until she had become tired. Meldoa decided it was best to wait until this moment, that way she wouldn't feel guilty doing her work, it was all going to run into the night anyways.

SIRCE

Sirce Woke up in his bed after another work week gone by, his muscles ached but they always did when he first woke. He slowly got up, enjoying the small respite he had this Sunday, when the wolfkin

would grant at the very least a single day off.

He then noticed the sweat on the sheets below him, his neighbors often talked to him about his screaming and wailing, it was three months now since it happened, he imaged he would've gotten over it by now, but the memory of the cable snapping from the crane and the resulting aftermath still shook him, at this point the only thing he wanted was his shoulder to return to how it was.

He stepped into his pantry taking a slice of meat off of a dried carcass, a gift he received from a local butcher after helping him pay off his debts to a gang, it's done him well these past few months. Since then took note of all the little things inside, compiling a list in his head of the goods he

will need to get on his trip out, he didn't have a lot of money but a few cents can bring you a long way with what he was shopping for.

He quickly left his apartment hoping to make this journey quick as it was his final day off and he was hoping to spend the rest of it in the park. He never really was a fan of his apartment it was cramped, dusty, and obviously needed some love from the landlord, but he knew it wasn't going to get any better there besides, he'd rather look at the flowers.

He didn't necessarily like flowers in the way most people like them, as in the beauty they bestow, he liked them more that they reminded him of home, his mother is a florist whom saw some pretty big wiggled visitors and paid far more than what she asked for, and his

father was a carpenter hence Sirce's last name.

But even with all the financial backing from there affluent visitors they where few and far between, the little customers, the locals always made the bulk of there sales, and they where leaving there local town in droves as all the skilled labor went to the city's, and despite Sirce's skills in both his mothers and fathers trade, he's found himself in the gutter at a warehouse.

It wasn't hard to figure out why, why hire someone who has years of experience when you can hire an idiot off the street, tell him how to use a machine, and walk away as he produces an identical piece to that of an actual carpenter, and all the floral shops are small, local, and don't pay well either,

he was hoping to land a spot at Spectacle a world renowned flower garden and flower shop but that was in vain as wolfskin where only allowed to work there, in fact all the places with good pay only hired wolfskin.

In a way Sirce kinda wished he was stupid, because then at least he would feel like he was getting a good deal, but he knew that wouldn't be a good predicament either, he exhaled as he went into the local market, scanning the shelves for what he needed.

Canned peas, onions, potatoes, he wondered what he'd do if mom hadn't taught him how to cook, he then went to make his purchase. "Hey, Sirce." Sirce at this point was a regular, a rather helpful regular as he often was paid for odd jobs, fixing doors, dressers,

cabinets, point was the local apes knew who to go to when something beyond there scope happened.

"Hey, Neeva." Neeva wasn't a very tall man, malnourishment from what he heard had it's way with him in his youth, even despite the fact he's been stealing food from people here since he was little, and due to his experience's he was the one who helped Sirce the most upon coming here, especially when it came to avoiding trouble.

"Hey." Sirce replied, Neeva then looked at Sirce's shoulder, "is it still busted," Sirce nodded. "Wish we had a doctor." Sirce said, "Yeah, wish they let us into the collages, at least then we'd have less assholes." Sirce chuckled, "Say how was it back home?" Neeva asked, Sirce shrugged, "not too bad, the wolfkin where nice too."

"Really?" Neeva ask, sounding surprised, Sirce nodded, "yes, of course I don't know how it is now, it's probably a ghost town," Neeva nodded, "ghost town sounds preferable to all of this." He sorta exhaled.

"Sorry those fucking extortionists came today, I'm just feeling down again." Oh it's that time, Sirce thought, "it's alright we all need to let it out," Neeva smiled. "Maybe one day I can run in a field," Sirce shook his head, "land owner will shoot yeah," Neeva exhaled again, "fucking dammit you can't run away from it can yeah." Sirce nodded, "still better then here I guess," they both chuckled, "well, have a good one, Neeva." Neeva raised his hand, "and to you the same."

Sirce, then left and continued

back to his apartment, feeling a little homesick, but he had to stay here so that his mother and father wouldn't suffer his current fate, as in his mind the family couldn't suffer a worst fate then losing the greenhouse and workshop.

Once, Sirce put away his acquired goods, he then left for the park planning to enjoy the rest of his afternoon secretly collecting seeds, and sending them back to his mother.

The next day he quickly made himself something to eat as he knew he was going to be worked to the bone once again, and he could only imagine the extent his shoulder could bare, last time he went to work he had to get someone else to help him pick up some crates, luckily they where sympathetic enough to help.

And as he suffered throughout the day his wolfkin manager came to him. "Boss, want's to see you upstairs." The wolfkin spoke, Since then followed, am I being fired, he thought feeling a little anxious as he climbed the stairs, he then entered the room and notice a woman he hadn't recognized standing across from the boss, she turned around and look at him with an apprising glare.

"So this is the one you want to be ride of," the wolfkin woman said. His boss then leaned back in her chair, "yeah, he blew his shoulder out from the crane accident he's been slow ever since," the strange woman walked a little closure, "eh, he will do, Its'ven." He felt someone he hadn't notice grab his shoulder, "come on, follow me ape," Since had begun to

find the word more then distasteful in his time here it was used for everything in reference to his race, simplified, derogatory, with no sense or thought placed behind the people it described, like he isn't even something that's worth thinking about.

However, there where no objecting these commands if he was a little more proud and a little more stupid he could protest, but with how everyone acted in this room to each other he knew that these where all members of a family, so all he could just do was hope that whatever they where planning wasn't going to be his end.

He soon found himself being escorted to a car, a stack of papers laying on the seat across from him, the wolfkin Its'ven he

believed his name was called, getting in first finding the large man in the middle, the female wolfkin soon coming out of the warehouse finding her seat across from him, separated by Its'ven.

"Mr. Carpenter, my name is Meldoa Ackscene from here on out I will be your fiancée," Since began to sweat, he new he wasn't important and that there was no reason for him to be held at such a level to be married into a family, unless he was meant to be played as some pawn in a game he didn't understand.

"And I will word this plainly, since you are an ape, I have no intention to actually marry you or bear your children, only in the event I require to I will do so in both prospects, however you are merely just to act like my fiancée."

Sirce was at first understandably in shock, which eventually made it's way into an onset of depression, as he knew or at least felt like he knew, he was going to become a pet bird in a gilded cage with no will of his own, he only hoped however he'd be as valued as a pet pigeon.

That fact might be exciting for some whom posses certain proclivities, but to him it was a sentence worse then death, what was to become of his mother and father, money, freedom, was this going to be indefinite? All these questions swirled in his mind, still he kept a poker face.

He gently brought his glare to the woman who called herself Meldoa, "is there pay." "Sure, now that you say it I'll give you an allowance... Hmmm, yes ground

rules," Sirce, knew this was going to be the moment that was going to decide whether it was going to be a prison or a well looked after prison.

"You'll be given your own room where you may place your personal belongings, however you cannot damage that room, also you may not leave the premises without, my permission, or without me in company." A gilded cage just as he predicted, "my butler will lay down the rest of the ground rules, as well as teach you proper manners."

He exhaled to himself, he could jump out of the car now, it'll hurt but, He looked at the lock, it's pressed down they'd notice and catch on in an instant, then they continue to suspect every move he'd make would come with intent to escape, better to wait for a better

opportunity.

"Understood." The woman said, he then looked back at the woman, "I guess." She then gave him a less then delightful expression.

"Understood, mam," he then added, can't be passive aggressive with her. "Good."

After some time, they soon arrived at what he assumed was her manor, he quickly noted the large yard, hoping that they at least let him out there to enjoy himself once and awhile.

They then entered her complex, there where a few guards, but nothing to write home about, probably didn't need them all the way out here, Since thought, however nothing about the place eased him, he was alone with no one to fight for him but himself, and

while many mistreatment's by wolfkin where mostly verbal, there where plenty who preferred violence.

The butler then came down from the second story. "Is, this your, "**husband**," milady." Meldoa nodded, the butler gave him an apprising look, but it was less assigning value to a pet, and more determining the usefulness of a person, "hmm, quite young, say I heard you worked in a warehouse." The butler said as he stood in front of him. "Yes," he stroked his well groomed beard. "Good, I could use the help."

There was then a period of silence, Meldoa locking eyes with the butler, "milady, we've finished up early for today in terms of menial tasks, may I show him his courtiers, and hand him his uniform

and let him rest up." Meldoa nodded, "I do not see a reason not to."

"You may follow me then, oh and what might your name be." "Sirce." The butler nodded. "It's a pleasure to make your acquaintance then, Sirce, mine is Noventon." The butler then quickly changed his direction to one of the lower wings of the manor, Sirce in tow.

While, Sirce was still concerned by those that surrounded him in this place, he was beginning to like the butler even though he obviously share some sentiments with the other wolfkin, he was nether hostile, or demanding, it felt weird to Sirce, at this point in time, to be treated with some semblance of respect by a wolfkin.

The butler then approached a

door, and opened it revealing the small interior, with a single bed pressed against the wall, "this will be your quarters from now on," Sirce nodded as he continued inside, well at least it's cleaner than my apartment, he thought.

"I'll let you familiarize yourself with your quarters, I'll come back to pick you up for supper." Sirce turned around nodding, the door then closing behind him, he exhaled as he sat on the bed, he knows there some people that would not, complain about this predicament but that's just because they have nothing to lose, and Sirce now has to think about how all those things might change.

NOVENTON

The butler continued into

Meldoa's room, the butler ashamed of the mess she has created, a giant mess that he isn't going to hear the end of especially from her father, but he never imagined she would actually do it, indeed he has listened to her rambles countless time of her desires to rid her fathers worry's that she will not come into possession of a child.

But to actually do it, has her father actually driven her mad. He knocked on the door, "who is it," Meldoa said through the door. "Nove'," "Come in." He continued in, Meldoa sitting at her desk seeming happy with herself.

Nove' knows she won't listen to reason, at least not to the reasons that first come to mind for him, indeed Nove' has learned to think differently about the apes having been forced to work with them in

these environments for so long and while he still holds some prejudices, by and large he mostly consider's them somewhat equal, a rarity now days.

"milady, I think it would be wise to reconsider what you've done," she exhaled, "you sound like my father," the butler pinched his brow, "milady, there are plenty of wolfkin out there who would dream of this moment, why this poor sod." She looked up at him, "because then father would be begging for a child," she configured her hand into the likeness of a gun, "it's supposed to be a threat, something to scare him with." The butler sighed, "you do realize many would consider this degenerate behavior," she chuckled, "and what throw out one of the people he relies on to keep this ship running."

At this point the butler was done arguing, he knew he lost the minute she took a different moral stance than him, that moral stance being to shut her father up at all cost's. "Children," the butler muttered.

"Well, that is all for today, tomorrow I will put him to work, and we'll see what I make of him," She nodded, "hopefully he's useful," she said with a smile, knowing full well that her plan was beginning to come to form, now all that was left for Meldoa to do was to order a pair of engagement rings and make her threat official.

SIRCE

Sirce awoke, feeling grateful for the bed, but spiteful of the prison, he wasn't sure how long

this whole husband thing was going to last for all he knew he would have to act like this indefinitely, he exhaled, he hoped by then he could form at the very least an attempt to escape.

He slowly got up, putting on his uniform, a simple dress shirt, covered by a black jacket with the family crest worn as a necklace. He continued out into the main hall where the butler had told him to meet him in the morning during breakfast, Noventon he believed his name was, he was still getting used to all the names, especially of those belonging to the entirely wolfkin staff, which he knew was small from listening to the banter of some wealthy people, a conversation that took place when he was just a child.

Sirce exhaled as he walked the

halls to the entrance, which was only a short walk to the quarters of the workers and servants, then coming across, Nove' who was dusting some of the railings despite them almost looking spotless. "Ah, Sirce glad to see I did not need to wake you," Sirce nodded, still feeling a little groggy as now his entire sleep schedule had changed, although he couldn't complain as it had changed to be more in favor with his personal health.

"Now, if you'll follow me we are going to be cleaning the masters quarters, as well as the other servants rooms, and if the load comes we'll do that also," Sirce nodded, despite not knowing what, "the load," meant but he figured he'd find out soon enough.

"Alright, let's not waste time

we only have so many hours to clean." Sirce followed the butler down the hall into a little room that hoarded all sorts of cleaning supplies and equipment, "grab a cart Sirce, we'll start with the master's chambers." Sirce nodded, grabbing one of the carts, Sirce following him to a small electric elevator that appeared to be hidden in the wall.

"You'll be using this to fairy things around quite a bit so don't be afraid to make good use of it, also the weight limit is 500 pounds, don't forget that," Sirce immediately understood what the man was insinuating. They then continued up the stairs up to the third floor, and taking the cart out of the elevator then continuing down the hall into the master's chambers.

"Seems she took her paper work to bed, explains why she looked like she was in such a sorry state," Nove' stated, as he made the bed all while Sirce was walking around the room dusting. Sirce was somewhat familiar with home care at least familiar enough to the point where he knew what would make you do it again.

"Ugh, sir," Sirce said, pulling up a piece of undergarment from under a dresser, "Oh, throw it in the bin, we'll put it with the rest of madams laundry." Sirce nodded, doing as he was told, "I'd imagine she'd be more put together," Sirce commented as he went back to brushing, "I ugh," he then stumbled on his words once he realized what he just said, "we'd all like to be, to be honest I hated serving her sisters and brothers more." Sirce

exhaled and chuckled a little, feeling comfortable in the fact that he can lower his guard.

"Is that so," Sirce said with quite a bit of curiosity. "Oh, indeed this ones just focused on her work the others though are mischievous trolls." Sirce looked at the butler for a moment, "now when I was young I could keep up with them but now I'm old and gray and can't stand the nuisance, and this is why I prefer working for the madams father, and the madam herself." Sirce nodded, " I assume it's that they treat things more seriously." The butler nodded, "but I fear Meldoa might treat certain serious things with some childishness, like." He quickly stopped his tongue, "I believe it wise to stop talking before I say something I don't mean," Sirce

nodded his head, carious but understanding to why the old butler stopped, he too also needed to be careful of such things.

The two then finished cleaning the madams chambers, not without some more surprises from Sirce, whom found more woman's cloths as well as some bread that was logged between the wall and the leg of the nightstand, mold covered as one might imagin. "I keep telling her not to bring food into the chambers," Nove' said, speaking like an adult disappointed in there child.

They then walked past a pair of glass double doors, Sirce feeling the familiar warmth caressing his skin, he immediately stopped and looked out into it seeing nothing but weeds suffocating the many flowers, herbs, and other plants

meant to be growing in there place, although Sirce, never really thought the plants as weeds they are just plants at the end of the day, "does anybody take care of it." Sirce asked, the butler walked back to Sirce looking into the greenhouse, "supposedly," Sirce looked at Nove', "we hire a gardener but I'm convinced he doesn't really do anything," Sirce cocked his brow "probably should fire him," the butler nodded, "indeed, indeed, but that is not my decision to make, and right now we have no one to replace him."

A horn then sounded off towards the back of the manor, "oh, thank goodness the load here's, come Sirce." Sirce exhaled, disappointed he didn't get to at the very least do something that he was familiar with, but he knew if he did so when

on the clock, he was sure to attract the ire of those that reside here.

They then reached the small loading dock that was just behind the manor, a loading dock which provided quick access to the pantry. The butler quickly found a seat on a crate, "after you Sirce, I'm getting too old," Sirce nodded understanding, but still disappointed that he now has to do this with less help.

The truck then pulled into the loading dock the step to the bed of the truck looking a little banged up, "oh no," the butler said, seeming familiar with the truck, it then stopped, and then came back slamming into the concrete dock. The butler closed his eyes, and exhaled, a few men some are then came out of the truck, some of them

looking tense, with one having what some might say a stupid look on his face. "Hey guys, what this thing doing here." Sirce then understood the need for extra air that the butler took, to be considered a thing by a wolfkin, whom obviously has intellect of a child whom was dropped on it's head would drive anyone to violence.

Sirce then began unloading the truck, with the others, who seemed to have had there fill today, whilst the idiot was over near the butler talking to him, the butler having a difficult time engaging in the conversation, a few minutes then passed, and they had reached some of the heavier boxes that where placed farther into the truck, Sirce was quick to grab one, expecting nothing of it until his arm reminded him of what had been

done to it.

He fell to the ground, dropping the crate as a sudden pain came from his shoulder, he quickly laid on his good shoulder, grasping onto the one in pain as saliva filled his mouth, as he heard some laugh around him.

The butler was very familiar with pain, he was old after all, and he had a good idea of what Sirce was experiencing. "Sirce," he said staring at the poor ape, lying on the ground waiting for the pain to subside, he slowly turned to face him.

"Would you head to the greenhouse I think you wanted to do something in there," the only thing that the butler could do at the vary moment is give Sirce, some light work, although the butler

knew that what he really needed was plenty of rest, and a doctor, but he knew those where tall orders when referring to an ape, so indeed the only thing he could do was go light on the poor lad.

The butler then quickly made himself useful, despite his back pain, at least it got him away from the idiot, and after thirty minutes the load was brought off the truck, the old man exhaled as he looked at the three pallets of stuff all cobbled together he had hopped that, Sirce would be able for this part but knowing his condition he didn't want to put farther stress on it, he then thought for a moment and supposed he could see if one of the woman or men where willing to conduct more dutys, either that or he will be doing it by himself again.

He came down the hall, the one that connected to the greenhouse, looking and hoping to see if Sirce was alright, what he found was was pretty much half of the greenhouse floor covered with dirt, and what he hoped where weeds all over the floor, he continued in straying away from the dirt, trying to keep his shoes clean, and to prevent the rage of the individual who was in charge of keeping the floors clean today, he walked throughout the greenhouse a bit until he found Sirce, sitting on a crate packing up some seeds, in paper whilst holding his shoulder.

"You do relize I sent you out here with the intention that you'd take it easy," Nove' said impressed by his work ethic, but still concerned for his health. "Sorry, just got carried away," Nove'

nodded. "How bad is the arm anyways," Sirce looked up at him, remaining kinda silent, "I can't fire you, not that I would all I could just do is give you less laborious work," Sirce then nodded, "sometimes, I can barely lift a tea cup other times it hurts to pick up anything with real weight." The butler was certain now he tore a muscle, his rotator cuff to be more precise. "I heard you got into an accident before you came here, care to elaborate," he scratched the back of his head, "a pallet of shit fell on it I got lucky," the butler paused. "I see, let's get you cleaned up then, and put some ice on it I'll put you in charge in finishing up what ever you where doing," Sirce nodded, and the butler went to find some help.

About an hour later, the butler

found his way into Meldoa's office leaving Sirce to wander around the manor, dusting and cleaning, "how is he doing," Meldoa said playing with the pen on her desk, as she stared at the papers that laid on it, "well miss Meldoa, I have no complaints only that he should see a doctor." She immediately scoffed at the idea, "I doubt that is worth it," "well it might be good to keep up appearances," she contemplated it for a moment, "nah, it isn't noticeable," well, he tried.

"Very well, but I do request that you go easy on him that arm is easily provoked into intense pain, also I'd rather not lose someone who seems to be doing rather well for himself, especially when it comes to gardening," Meldoa leaned forward, "gardening?" "Yes milady, gardening, I don't know much of it

myself but he seems confident in what he's doing, not much harm he can do anyways the bed was overrun with weeds." She paused, "indeed, well if he is any good we can finally get rid of that useless wolfkin," "indeed, madam." There was then a pause the butler wondering if he should press her once more into abandoning her objective and just making him a servant.

She then opened a drawer, pulling out two box, each containing engagement rings, "Nove', tomorrow I will intend to put my plans in motion," she looked at the butler with a mischievous smile, "I'm putting you in charge of insuring that we are served tomorrow," Nove' was now certain there was no talking her out of this so he decided to go for the

next best thing her father,
"understood, milady I will see to
it, now is that all." Meldoa then
opened one of the boxes, and
lifting up the ring contained
inside, "yes, I believe that is
all."

The butler then continued out,
skipping past his dutys that where
once at the forefront of his mind,
instead slipping into his private
room, picking up the telephone that
laid inside, "hello," a voice
sounded off from the other side,
Nove' immediately remembering who
it belong to, "hello, Dianna, ugh
may you be so kind as to route me
to Junias residence," "oh, yes,
right away Nove'." Nove', then
waited a few moments before he
heard Junias's voice on the other
line, "yes," "master, it is I Nove'
I wish to inform you of a

development at the manor," Nove' heard Meldoa's father lean forward, "your daughter has recently gotten into some mischief, and um is threatening to marry an ape whom was recently forced into service in the manor." He heard his master stand, "**WHAT!**", what indeed the butler thought to himself.

"I'm going down there this instant," oh, we can't be having that, "master, master please listen," there was then silence on the other end, until he heard his master sit, "continue, Nove'," Nove' exhaled, "sir, your daughter was beginning to become overwhelmed by your persistent request to bare child, that she has decided to act out in this manner," he then heard his master exhale powerfully over the phone, "I have been quite pushy haven't I," the butler nodded in

silent agreement. "I also recommend you don't run into this mess like a bull, your daughter is rather stubborn and I'm afraid she'd do something rash, plus she'd know it was me right away," he heard his master then readjust himself in his chair. "why are things like this, she's the only one who hasn't been a handful and now she goes on and does this," the butler smirked, "the quiet one does seem to be the most troublesomely intelligent,"

"you mean stupid," the butler wagged his finger despite no one being present, he enjoys talks like these allows him to get away with acts of judgment without getting so much as a glare,

"being intelligent doesn't mean one is socially," the butler heard a small chuckle,

"here, here to that, is that all,"

"I do believe so, sir."

"then farewell, and make sure she doesn't do anything more stupid until tomorrow," the butler then hung up, and brought his fingers to his temples, "children," he muttered, "always giving us two headaches," he then continued out, and searched for Sirce to tell him to get some rest, because tomorrow for him would be most harrowing.

THE NEXT DAY

SIRCE

Sirce awoke, and although his bed was comfortable, still he wished he was back in his apartment at least it would be a place where he felt safe, instead of being

surrounded by wolfkin strangers, he then got up, looking at his pocket watch, I wonder if I'm ever going to get my personal belongings from the apartment, he exhaled, probably not, Sirce then got up and got dressed, heading out to the dutys board to see where he was placed, he then quickly saw that it was in fact his day off, hmm that doesn't make any sense he thought, pondering if it was a mistake, he figured they'd be working him for at least a few consecutive days just to get him used to things.

He shrugged, all well, looks like it's the day off. "Sirce," he heard the butler from behind, Sirce quickly turned around and straightened himself, causing his back to tense up in pain as well as his shoulder. "Ow," he quickly yelped silently, "Meldoa, plans to

have lunch with you, and I've been tasked with preparing you an appropriate suit," oh, Sirce thought to himself.

"Lunch," Sirce said, "indeed, she uh, has her reasons," Sirce knew what the butler was referring he knew it because that was his only stated purpose, to be the puppet husband of a wolfkin woman, everything else like his new job, and his pay where probably only done to keep him in check under his own will.

"Are you ready, Sirce, uh, I mean sir," Sirce cringed at the mention of him being a sir, it's not like he earned it with the butler, which was an odd thing to think considering he's a wolfkin and he's an ape, "umm, you can keep calling me," the butler immediately shook his head, "I do prefer the

name Sirce in comparison to the title, but if I don't the madam will be greatly displeased with me," Sirce nodded. "Where to," the butler turned to the door, "after me, sir."

Sirce then followed the butler into a dressing room, "I'm also supposed to take your measurements for other wears," Sirce tilted his head, "can't I just use these," the butler shook his head, "Meldoa wouldn't marry someone of poor birth, unless there was a certain fantastical circumstance, plus if your husband was walking around wearing a servants dress many would think that she had used her power in unsavory ways," Sirce squinted his eyes at Nove'. "But she did," the butler stretched the measuring tape, "indeed. She. Did, but I recommend not bringing that up."

"Now disrobe your overcoat, I need to make sure my measurements are accurate," Sirce did as the butler said and the butler quickly began taking measurements, "your quite slim," said Nove' who was going around the waist, "yeah, my mom had to sew a good portion of my pants waistlines tighter so they would fit properly," the butler nodded, "hmm, I assume you came from a good upbringing then." "Yeah, I was an only child," the butler raised an eyebrow, "only," "yeah, my mom lost her ability to conceive after I was born, so I was given a lot of attention, and all the work," the butler chuckled, "I see."

The butler then stepped away, and opened a drawer, "and where did you learn to garden, from what I understand your last name is

Carpenter," Sirce nodded, "blame my mother, I still know how to work with wood, just gardening is kinda my forte," Nove', then took a prepared suit from drawer, bringing it to Sirce, "well sounds like your well rounded, I'm surprised you got stuck with warehouse work," Sirce shrugged, "wolfkin don't take kindly to me," Nove' then exhaled, as if remembering if he had forgotten something. "of course, you'd think they care more about money," Sirce laughed, "apparently not," the butler then gave Sirce his suit.

"Now then I'll leave the room, knock, and call my name when you are ready, and I'll share the rest of what is to come of today with you," Sirce nodded and Nove' left the room, Sirce then began to change, and thoughts began pouring

in he didn't think the work was bad, in fact it was quite easier on his body, and he partially enjoys his supervisor who seems to look at him as an equal, the pay was comparable to his last job too, however he would enjoy some time at his private residence obviously he still didn't like the fact he was forced here but he has soften to the prospect of it, still however being force to display himself as ones husband did not sit well with him especially since it's a wolfskin where he knows she'll subjugate him to her every whim, he remembered what she said when it came to both marrying and bearing, indeed the last thing he wanted for himself and any potential children, was to be held down and raped by some sick woman.

He then knocked on the door and

Nove' opened it. "ha, there, any bagging, no, Hmmm just around the cuffs, oh, nope too long at the skirt, the butler then took some pins out of his pocket and brought the overcoats waist up a bit." He then stood back, "that should work," he then exhaled, "are you her personal tailor," he stook his head, "good heavens no, I had to leave yesterday to get advice in the city, I do hope this holds up."

Sirce looked at him with pity, "does she just dumps things on you," the butler paused for a moment his eyes darting into the corner of his eyes, "usually no," he then leaned for inviting a whisper, Sirce accepted, "in all honestly she's better then her siblings, but this latest event has put me over the edge," Sirce stepped back, "oh," he then nodded,

"well then let's talk while we walk."

They then set down the halls to the dinning hall, "her father is supposed to be coming today, which is why she expedited this, she actually wanted to slowly trust you with your position, but he immediately went into talking about her finding husband last morning and it set her off," Sirce closed his eyes hoping that whatever the father does, he doesn't blame him, and that he mentions nothing of a child to this implosive bitch, opps, he can already here his mother a mile away.

"Now Sirce do you know anything of etiquette," he thought for a moment, "manors," "oh, um, hands off the table, speak when spoken too... Eat whats in front of you," the butler then exhaled, "well it's

clear you have an understanding, but you wont pass we will stick to introductions, if anything weird happens I will pass it off that you did not sleep well last night," Sirce nodded, and Nove' then opened the door, "we will continue with proper etiquette once this passes."

The two then continued in, Meldoa sitting at the other end of the table with a grin on her face, "good you've finally arrived, I apologize for the sort notice of all of this," Sirce felt that the line wasn't fully directed to him, and wish she was at least somewhat as sympathetic as the butler, Sirce quickly found his seat at the other end as it seemed like the most natural position, including that it was the farthest away from the witch that kidnapped him.

"Well then, Sirce do you mind if

you greet me," Sirce stared at her for a moment, "hello, Madam." Sirce was not in a good mood, and it poured through his words, and actions, indeed his body and mind spoke from the heart and he knew it, and he knew it would probably get him killed in this place.

"My, my your either trying your best to insult me, which is cute, or I seriously overestimated your intelligence," the butler sensed the rising hostility and that no party in the room was preventing it, he sensed that Meldoa wanted this for some reason, "I don't think the dockside has the qualities your looking for then."

The butler saw, Meldoa developed a short and subtle grin, she's treating this like an outing to a party, reading his emotions, evaluating his inner person, every

word an attempt at testing him, he exhaled, don't play ball with her Since you don't even know what this world is like, she'll tear you apart, just play dumb and smother your hate.

"C'mon can you blame a woman for wanting a rough and tough husband." Nove' felt the hate emanating off of Sirce the kinda hate that was uncomfortable to sit around, "if only that where true," she rested her hand on her chin.

"Very good, keep going like that you might end up with one of my garbage thrice removed relatives, hmm no that would be a waste, we won't keep it at one" she chuckled at the last word, and annoyingly fabricated chuckle meant to provoke, what are you judging Meldoa, Nove' thought almost whispering it to himself

subconsciously.

She then got up from her chair and walked over to Sirce, his eyebrows fully down his eyes hate filled eyes staring her down passionately, there's nothing like taking away a mans agency to make him like that, Meldoa sat on the table halfway, she wanted to provoke him knowing he'd be targeted, she wanted to see how he would react, how he would respond, gauge how much control she'd have to bring onto him in events like these, so far there's hostility but that's to be expected, whats important is that he knows where he is and whether he's actively controlling these emotions or not, so far he's doing rather well, not accounting for the banter of course but everyone needs a little sharp tongue to defended themselves and

he has it, he might not be as clever but he has it.

"your not vary good at self control Sirce arn't you," Nove' silently sighed, so that is what this is, he pondered while looking at the two, indeed Meldoa wanted a good appearance when it came to this, the threat had to feel real after all and she needed someone who was either subservient or knowledgeable enough to know what was to be done.

"What do you mean by that, I'm just sitting here, like is expected of me," Meldoa smiled, "expected indeed," yes he needs work, like every new comer would need, but he did a good job at diverting his rage and that was enough for her to consider him fully.

"Congratulations, you won," she

said putting herself in arms reach of the boiling man, she then put the case for the engagement ring on the table, looking at him for longer then a second, then leaning down to him remaining a sort distance from is face, "today you'll meet my father, and you'll act like my loving husband unless you want to end up in a river some where, it's all up to you of course," Meldoa was surprised Sirce's anger didn't turn to fear in that moment, she knew she had someone mentally strong, it made her ponder for a moment but it was just a vapid thought. She then brushed his cheek with the back of her hand, her skin sliding across his clean shaven cheek.

"Now let's eat Sirce, and when father comes play your part." She then signaled the rest of the staff

with a bell, and quickly food began pouring in, he will learn to like it here, Meldoa thought to herself as a plate was brought to her.

THE KINDLING OF HATE ENCAGED

SIRCE

Sirce stood behind Meldoa whom sat in a chair, looking at her father who seemed to be taking everything well, but Sirce knew it was just a front and that this was in fact his worse nightmare, Sirce felt a little camaraderie in that, that he was not completely alone in his thoughts.

"Ha, so your my daughter's fiance, it's about time," he said with a giggle that betrayed him, Sirce looked down at Meldoa, seeing poisonous smile stretched from ear to ear, "indeed it is father indeed it is," Sirce brought his hand

across his chest forming it in a cup just like Nove' told him too, "my name is Sirce, Junias Ackscene," he nodded, "well then welcome to the family Sirce, I hope you treat my daughter well," Junias fought the words out of his mouth not that he necessarily hated Sirce, or wouldn't accept him as a person but at the fact the most stable of his daughters had actually done the unthinkable.

What the hell are you thinking, Junias wanted to shout but as with anything such a public outburst would not reflect kindly onto him, and now at this most delicate moment in the relationship between the Ternia family, he needs the outward appearance of the family to be strong. He looked up at Sirce, and decided perhaps he can make the unwilling participant crack under

pressure. "So Meldoa, how did you meet this man, not a lot of humans like to come visit here," he was right the only time apes actively came here was for an explicit purpose, like a diplomatic envoy, or because they where forced to by other means, this would challenge the first foundation of there 'love', how they met.

Meldoa smiled, "he was simply on an envoy trip, made a good first impression, and we exchanged a few letters, and we eventually decided it was a good time to do so."

Junias leaned forward, it was not hard to tell that he was thinking deeply Since was growing nervous as he thought about what it'd mean if he got confirmation, that there relationship was a false one, what would she do.

Junias kept staring at the two,

this is a waste of time I should just accost her right here right now, he thought as he leaned back in his chair, "Sirce do you mind if you take a step out for right now," Sirce then looked at Meldoa, and she and he went out the door.

JUNIAS

"Meldoa, my daughter, what the hell are you doing," she leaned back and crossed her legs, "oh whatever do you mean," she said sarcastically, "enough," her father put on a tone she knew would only spell trouble if she didn't respond properly, "I've force an ape to become my husband in order to stop you from pestering me." They both sat in silence, the father exhaled, "in what way was I pestering you," she looked at her father

disapprovingly, "oh, I don't know the blind dates, the weird meet ups with members of the opposite sex, the talks about artificial insemination," Junias pinched his brow, "Meldoa, I am looking out for you, for the family," Meldoa's face contorted, "oh really, well how would you like if you where told, by your father, to have sex with some random girl you just met," Junias stared at the floor for a second. "Listen, I am... If your going to be come head of this family, I want you to at least to have child... I need to make sure that your legacy is preserved because the minute you enter my spot there will be people who will challenge your claim," she spoke slowly so that there would be no room more misinterpreted words, with him pausing every so often

to collect his thoughts, Meldoa remained firm in her expression of anger.

"Really that's what this is about a lineage, I understand my responsibility's, but to be treated like this by my own father is disgusting," Junias felt a wound produce itself one his soul, "Meldoa, I," Meldoa gripped the chair, "I hoped, you'd at least respect my agency and my ability to determine when the time was right, and whom was deserving enough to receive that right," her father then looked off to the side of the room, feeling a coming onset of guilt, "but clearly that's not the fucking case," Junias remained silent, perhaps I have made an error, he thought to himself, perhaps I have been too hasty.

"I'm sorry," Meldoa scoffed,

"he will stay in my midst for the time being," Junias picked up his head, "Meldoa," she then brought her knuckles onto her chin, "I have no reason to trust that you won't continue your assault, he will stay, and if you continue your actions I will bear his child."

Junias understood all the implications of this, how this would send shock waves through the wolfkin population, how the daughter of a wolfkin elite, produce a mixed child, Junias shook at what could happen to the family if he kept her in the fold and what it would mean losing her.

If he was disguised as an elite it would seem like the marriage was completely political, he could arrange a few shell companies to be made, do some fake exports and imports that are favorable, as long

as no child was born people would scoff but they would understand, "your supposed to make my life easier you know." She folded her arms, "you to," he closed his eyes, he knew he was in no position to decline this either this is her house and these are her rules.

"I'll support you in this endeavor, and I'll stop harassing you, just don't conceive a child." She smiled, "thank you for coming to an understanding," he nodded exhaling, "anyways lets finally get back to talks about everyone else's financial situations," Junias crossed his fingers hoping that the rest of his sons and daughter have decided to be kind to him this year.

The talks went on until it was time for supper, something Junias was hoping to be able to avoid, as

he wanted to be home with his wife sharing a meal, but alas he's found himself here endlessly talking about documents, maybe getting into the affairs of the elites was a mistake, and he should've just stayed a simple arms dealer.

"But as of right now I think an expansion is due in our jewelry business, seems foreigners have taken a liken to our wears," Junias nodded, "careful, we don't want to be caught in a fad," Meldoa nodded, noting the concern, this is why Junias likes Meldoa articulate, precise, she knows her way around sure she isn't a sweet talker, but everyone upon meeting her knews why she's where she is.

Junias then leaned back in the chair, letting his worries dissolve his children make him so stressed, yet Meldoa can manage it all, he

didn't see her as this super woman of course, but it was nice to talk to someone on his level when he got stuck up on something, instead of the conversation boiling down to excuses, and misunderstood jokes, indeed Junias felt like an island when it came to talking about anything.

"Carnis's business have been running in the red as of late," Junias leaned in, "any reason as to why," Meldoa looked at him. "He thinks he's getting sabotaged, of course there could be other factors as well but he believes someones tampering with the materials," Carnis business deals with cleaning supplies, acids, and other chemicals and materials related to scientific resource they also have a few agreements with collages for materials, but there most lucrative

business is saltpeter, and guncotton. "Which side of the business," Junias asked, "he needed to be pressed on the subject, it's our arms chemicals" there was then silence in the room, "how long has this been going on."

Junias was now getting frustrated, as Carni should know by now that he should be letting people know about manufacturing issues of this matter, "for a few months, I already put Its'van on the matter he's digging through, Carni's mess as we speak," Junias became only slightly relived by the fact but it was still concerning, how many loads of ammunition where sent out in that time, who did they go too, for all Junias knows the entire supply chain could be compromised with bad powder.

"I'll send a strongly worded

letter to him, about this," Junias said as he rested his head against his hand, "it's probably the Terina family too," Junias exhaled. "Is Its'van also looking into where those compromised shipments went," "yes," Junias nodded his head, "I'll send more men down there too, discreetly of course, also give me regular updates on the matter."

Junias looked at the entire stack of papers they had just gone through, "is it over," Meldoa nodded her head, "I believe so," Junias knows that the matter revolving around the Ternia family is elevating his emotions, although not to the point of irrationality, more that he can't tolerate mistakes at this point and how can he.

"What time is it," Junias asked, "6:30, father," "then I suppose I

shall be staying here for supper," even through Junias knew it, saying put a dagger in his heart and with this news coming in he wished he could just appear in front of his wife and share a meal with her, at least it would temper his frustration.

"Alright then Meldoa, I'll see you in the dining room, do bring your 'fiance' if you desire," Meldoa nodded with a smile, "of course."

SIRCE

Sirce was glad Meldoa let him leave the room, the air in there was suffocating with that man in there trying to choke every single detail about his current situation out of him, Sirce, then placed a once potted flower into the planter

box, bringing the extra soil over it's roots and gently patting it into place. That should do it for this section, he thought as he want to clean up the floor before a maid would come and berate him for making a mess, that happened often and he was sure they where doing it because he was an ape.

After a few minutes of cleaning Nove' came into the greenhouse, looking around for a few sort seconds, "well I think you might put that wolfkin out of business," he said sounding genuine, as he looked at one of the flower boxes he just worked on, "I doubt it Nove'," the butler exhaled, "trust me that woman is unbelievably unbiased when it comes to money," Sirce smiled, "so she's biased towards money" Nove' produced a smile from the smart ass remark,

"indeed so, oh, Meldoa is requesting you for supper," Sirce exhaled, "damn witch." He muttered, Nove' nodding, as Sirce stepped away and charged ahead of him.

And after a short distance Sirce, as well as Nove' soon found themselves at the front doors of the dinning room. "There's already a plate on the table for you sir, you may start eating once your seated," Sirce nodded, as Nove' opened the door for him, Sirce nodded as a way of demonstrating thanks and continued inside, Juinas sat across from Meldoa, Meldoa only looking up for a second, whilst Junias continued to keep watch of him, Sirce felt unsure what to make of this was he, protective of his daughter, or was he trying to measure what kinda man he was.

Sirce then sat next to Meldoa

as that was where the plate was placed, although he would've preferred to sit next to Junias, or even better all the way across the room, actually the breakroom with Nove' would've been the best choice but that wasn't going to happen in this situation.

Sirce then quickly went about eating his meal, "so, Sirce I heard that you like to garden," Sirce nodded, "picked it up from my mother," seems everything had boiled over well, Sirce thought, to be honest he was relived but also, kinda disappointed that her father hadn't figured it out.

"Ah, so your mother likes to garden, how vast is hers then," "pretty vast sir, and when I left an addition was being put on," Junias smiled, "well I suppose I should make a visit, it's been a

while since that greenhouse has looked right," Sirce nodded, well at least he's making small talk probably to prevent pissing off his daughter.

"But I would like to apologize for my daughter's behavior, plucking you out of a warehouse like that I'm sure gave you a rather sour impression," oh, the word carried a certain unsure quality in his mind, is everything okay, was he going to be let go, if so he hoped it was from the marriage department, he didn't mind servant work.

"Nove' can you fetch his pay records," Sirce cocked his head, what is this all about he pondered, Nove' quickly exited the room, Meldoa developing scowl soon after, "excuse me," she said with great offense, the father then sighed.

"Meldoa, he may be your butler but he and I both understand this situation is less then desirable," she scowled both at the door, and at her father, "so tell me Sirce how do you feel about this situation," Sirce then looked at Meldoa who seemed to be staring knifes at him, "I'm being treated well, however like any prisoner I desire my freedom," Junias nodded, "a fair assessment," Nove' then came in and placed a folder onto the table in which Junias then began to search through.

"Ah, here you are, Meldoa," he spoke with an exhaled. "your asking him to be both servant and fiance, at this pay," Meldoa seemed glare at here father, "he dosn't need to know that," he shook his head, "your inviting this human into your personal affairs you need to at

least pay him well, least be it someone else does," Meldoa quickly stopped glaring and stared at her plate.

Junias then took a pen and scratched out the original wage, "fourteen dollars," he said, "what, no, that's more then the others," Meldoa spoke as if insulted, "and are anyone of them your fiance," and she quieted herself once more, Sirce developed a smile, seeing the witch left in a state where her protests where meaningless and her authority was overshadowed by another.

Although this talk of wages, hmm, why indeed did his wage seem so high compared to every other place he looked at, I mean there was an obvious trend, I mean it was just a few cents but a few cents is a few cents, no matter who it came

from, and the hours, they where also more favorable, why there had to have been a reason.

But of course Sirce wasn't skilled in business or social affairs, or even history, however he had his wits, and the logic he inherited from math but when someone doesn't even have the concept of an incentive structure, it becomes hard to find how everything comes together.

Sirce then let the problem go for now, it still stuck in the back of his head however trying to figure out why it stuck out of him, of course he knew why he picked the job, and he knows why other people picked the job, but these people talked about it like it was really important, why, was it too take from other business's no that only just a small piece.

Sirce continued to attempt to wrap his head around it but like any new problem solutions where numerous and full of holes, however across the table, Junias gazed had drifted over to the man who had grown still, his eyes fixated on some random immobile spot on the table, he recognized as something a thinking man would do, Junias wondered whether his daughter had truly picked out a dock worker.

"Sirce, you seem to be lost in thought care to share anything," Sirce was then knocked out of his trance, looking dazed for a few seconds, "oh, uhh, no it's nothing," Junias rubbed his chin, "are you sure," "yes, I am." Junias shrugged, wondering what the man was truly thinking, but secrecy doesn't necessarily mean anything, well it could mean anything, so

Junias decided to let sleeping dogs lie.

Since for some reason felt stupid, he felt like the what he was asking himself was so simple, yet it eluded him. "So, Meldoa I have a question for you," she perked up all while Sirce was fighting to keep his thoughts restrained so he could keep up with the conversation, "ask away, father," "well, are you planning on taking him to the Serisca ball, "Meldoa thought for a moment, "perhaps, it would tell everyone that I am currently taken, it will certainly keep those minor family's away from me, and maybe it will provide the illusion of foreign backing without me uttering a single lie," her father smiled, "hopefully that is the case."

A ball, why the emphasis again,

why is it sticking in his head, Sirce was beginning to feel like his head was going into overdrive, so much so the entire room seemed to move two thirds slower then it was actually going at. He then heard a knock at the door, and so did everyone else, as they turned there heads to it.

Nove' quickly went over opening up the dinning room entrance by just a hair, until finally opening it up fully, Junias arose entirely in shock, but despite the initial reaction seemed genuinely happy at who had come to visit, indeed that every person was his wife, "Violy, what brings you here, I thought you where going to leave us to our business," not that he was complaining "I did say that didn't I," she said with a smile that reminded Sirce of the woman sitting

next to him.

"and you also said that you'd hope it wouldn't be long, but I cannot blame you," she then looked at Meldoa, "our daughter seems to have gone and done something unbecoming of her," there was a certain quietness that befell the room, "I'm sorry to ruin the meal, I understand that you might have worked past the issue yourself's but could everyone here give us a moment, please." She casted her gaze across the entire room, everyone seeming to nod, and exciting understanding that protesting would've elicited a rather uncomfortable scolding.

"Well I was hoping to enjoy at least a meal with her, it doesn't happen as often as it used to anymore," Sirce watched as the articulate man seem to slump a

little Nove' patting him on the back, "you'll have your moments Junias," "I hope so," he responded, Sirce smiled a little at the sight, kinda being remained of his own parents back home, making him forgot for a moment the situation he was in, "now she's probably going to take a while, scolding her," "tea in the drawing room sir," Junias scoffed at the idea waving his hand away, Nove' brought his eyes to Sirce, and then Junias did as well.

Sirce would've preferred having the garden to himself, he discovered that no one really ventured out here, most likely due to the heat, but it had somewhat been a cloudy day and it had cooled to a reasonable temperature, which lead him having to the share the room with Nove' and the head of the

family Junias as they ate crackers, and sipped tea, whilst having a wine bottle under the table in the event they ran out of first beverage.

but the only reason he would preferred being empty, was because he could feel the judging stare from Junias, it didn't belong to that of a wolfkin who was disgusted at the mere sight of an ape, it was more like a craftsman contemplating the use of a tool, but Sirce would not be surprised if it was the former, as he was getting glares all the time from his 'coworkers', he thought he had grown used to it but little does one realize the tax of it when there is no oasis of fellow humans.

Sirce worked while the two talked, finally cleaning out the last of the garden beds that had

over weeded at the front of the entrance, something that he decided to work towards when he first came here, now all he had to do was prepare for the second phase of rehabilitating the greenhouse, which was cleaning and planting out the middle section, he then exhaled as he looked out to it, it really was the first time he had done anything like this himself, as his mother was the one mostly managing the establishment he was just someone who did the ground work, he thought of course he was doing quite well, but he was sure his mother would find things he could do better. "Sirce, come join us you've been working the entire time we've been here," the voice came from Junias, Sirce turned around and looked at the two seeing that the wine bottle had preemptively

He sat down with the two, Nove' pouring him a glass of tea, "Nove' what's with this at least give the lad a good drink," Nove' then looked at Junias, "I do not think he has a preference for alcohol, sir," it was true, Sirce gets rather sever nausea, as well as hives from alcohol. He came to discover that when he was rather young. Not that he'd enjoyed it to begin with.

"Huh, well I suppose tea would make the better drink then," Junias then stared out at the up and coming garden, "well at least Meldoa got someone who can do work," Junias said with a laugh, he then leaned on the table placing his hand against his face, "I assure you sir, she was quite lucky, unfortunately I cannot say the same for master Sirce," Sirce

face slightly contorted at the mention of master, "ah, indeed she is, unfortunately we can't really do anything about it, well easily, especially as long as she feels strongly about this," everyone seemed to sigh, "hopefully, she's talking some sense into her right now."

MELDOA

Meldoa remained seated in the dinning room chair, as she listened to her mother accost her, seems her entire family has decided to dog pile her today, but she knew that was going to happen. It always took a certain amount to strain to tell someone to shut the fuck up. At least that's what she thinks.

Meldoa's mother exhaled, "was it truly that awful, it wasn't like he was forcing you." Meldoa casted a

gaze at here that said yes. "Well then, Meldoa. I cannot deny it either, for I too was frustrated, but I think that we can both agree this is an over reaction." Meldoa shook her head. "Meldoa, you have taken a stranger as your fiance, not only that but he is an ape. I understand, that your father prefers not to call them that, but that is what they are." Meldoa sighed. "I know who he is. This wasn't just some rushed decision made in the span of a second. I have watched him for some time, I know he likes shopping on his day off, prefers fresh produce over canned goods, he helped a local butcher with some of his business with us, the only thing I was surprised about was his affinity for gardening, as all I knew was that he also enjoyed the part and

Her mother adjusted herself in her seat. "Well then, I apologize for assuming anything less of my daughter. Still however, he doesn't belong here." Meldoa leaned against one of the arm rests of her chair. "Indeed, he doesn't, but we both know I'm not just going to let him go, because you and father tell me so. That's only going to happen when I no longer need him." Her mother scowled. "And when will that be." Meldoa smiled. "we'll see, maybe it will be tomorrow, or a few years from now, the point is I don't think father's learned his lesson." Her mother continued to stared at her an obvious look of objection possessing her. "Listen, I understand we've given you a certain level of independence, but is not how you should use it." Meldoa sighed. "We might as well

get father, and finish our now cold meals together." Meldoa's mother knew what she meant when she said that, that this conversation was going to go nowhere but circles, she arose from her chair.

"No, I believe I'm going to go home for today. You've made it far more eventful then I'd like." She then continued out the door leaving Meldoa, alone in the dinning room.

SIRCE

"And then there's the family they keep breathing down our necks." Junias was now well and drunk. Sirce, and Nove' looked at each other as the once calculating man, was now sprawled out onto the small table. "Seems he's had a lot on his mind." He said, watching the man he calls sir, cry. "I know it is unlikely but, Remind me not to

end up in his position." Sirce asked. Nove' nodding, his wife then entered into the garden, looking around the new scenery until bringing her eyes to her less than sightful partner. "Oh, Junias." She muttered out of pity, slowly walking up to him.

"I'm so sorry," she spoke to Nove', "it's okay madam, he's obviously been every stressed." The woman nodded, as she helped Junias up to his feet. "Yes he's had plenty on his mind, to be honest I was sure that he was going to enter one of his long brooding from the stress," Nove' nodded, "oh my, I would not want to be called back to service the master just to deal with that." They both nodded, as she began carrying him out.

Nove' then exhaled, "I'll ensure to ensure that next time it's just

the tasting wine," he said as he put the cork back onto the empty bottle. "Well, Sirce, what do you think of the family." I shrugged. "Just like any other." Nove' laughed. "Indeed, Sirce, indeed." We then heard the steps of a woman the gental clacks coming from the door, and echoing into the greenhouse.

"Is father still here, I want to say my goodbyes." Meldoa stated, Nove' shook his head. "He was dragged away by your mother, in a rather drunken state I might add." She exhaled, she then looked down at me quickly finding a seat and bringing it to the rest of us. "Are you here to berate us milady." Nove' asked, seeming somewhat amused by Meldoa's, expression of anger. "Well we can skip that part then." She said as she looked away.

"But now that I judged you for myself Sirce, I believe I will keep you." I look of disappointment went across Sirce's, face. "However, fathers correct, I do need to treat you properly for the service you provide, but just so you know I will reap every bit of value out of you." The words made Sirce uncomfortable, he knew it could entail anything within these walls, and the only person who could defend him has his hand tied.

"Meldoa, I think you should go light on the intimidation I believe it'd be better if we treated..." He stared at Meldoa as she stared back at him angrily, "very well, miss Meldoa." She then locked eyes with Sirce, "if I refuse." "You mean if your uncooperative, cement and swimming lessons are cheap you know." Nove' sighed. Sirce knew how

much wolfkin valued the lives of man, it could be the most obvious, cleanest open and shut case imaginable, and nobody would be charge, it was only when everyone was angry enough when something happened.

"Then I guess I have no choice." Meldoa nodded. "Indeed you don't." There was silence and Nove' looked at the two of them with concern. This is going to turn into a mess, he thought. "But let's put that aside and focus on business, here I want you to take the job of the grounds keeper and since your the only one Nove' will be handling your budget and expenditures, but your moneys yours, second you will act as my husband." "Yes you've told me that." She shook her head. "But I haven't told you the responsibility's, you'll come with

me, during balls and meetings I consider advantages, because although you are an ape your presence can merely invoke the thought of foreign support." Sirce tilted his head. "And why is that so important." He asked, she smiled. "Because Sirce, you try raiding a factory, or hitting a vehicle halfway across the globe, and besides foreign money can have it's advantages as well."

Sirce thought for a little bit. But they all hate us. "Won't they have a distaste for your new found 'ally'." She nodded. "Some will, but they all know that the nations of the newlands are prime for profit, even if they are no longer under wolfkin control." Sirce them remembered the revolt and the resulting twenty year war, one that took many lives, how he wished it

happened here in this moment.

"So I will have you trained in our ways, in order to sell that illusion, but even if it fails you'll always have other uses, but first we'll go over our plans." She then poured herself some tea. "In a few weeks I will have a meeting with a representative from the newlands, well he's more of a business tycoon, but that's neither here nor there. Anyways I want to secure some written agreements from him, and I figured you'd help break a little bit of the water." She then took a sip from her cup.

"There is also that ball I'm sure you heard it referenced during our meal, it is a very important political ball and I want you to partake in it." I exhaled, this sounds like it's going to be a lot of work, between managing the

grounds, and trying to play political husband to this crazy bitch.

Sirce exhaled. "Oh, come on now I'm sure there are plenty of people from your little enclave that would kill to be in this kinda position." Sirce looked down at the floor, and with out a thought. "I just wanna die quietly you dumb bitch." The words left with no effort, like they where a secret thought bubbling up inside. "Well, that can be arranged." Sirce jumped up. "Wait, wait, wait, you know what I mean by that." Meldoa chuckled, as Sirce panicked, and then exhaled with great relief, Nove', shook his head at the woman's poor taste of humor.

"Well then, I believe that's all we need to discuss, so lets get to work people." She said as she

clapped her hands, then throwing a glare at Nove'. We both sighed as she ventured off back into the estate. "Well that went better then expected." Nove' said, as he picked up the tea. "I was expecting an ear full but perhaps she decided it was not in her best interest." Sirce nodded. "I mean you are her best man, are you not?" Nove' smiled. "Indeed I am." he said with a chuckle, and continued out of the greenhouse.

Sirce then stared out into the greenhouse, not looking at anything in particular, just the events of today flowing through his mind, a lot of things have happened today the reach of such things have yet to be seen, but he can tell he's going to play a major roll in these peoples plans, whatever they may be. The problem is that Sirce feels

helpless against them, every time he tries to reason what they mean, or how their decisions will impact everything he hits a brick wall. Ignorance is a sin and this is his greatest one of all, and now Sirce is only left with the hope that he'll maybe someday have the knowledge to fight back against his captor.

THE NEXT DAY

"Sirce straighten yourself." Nove' said as he pressed his hand against his lower back. "When's that harness supposed to come in anyway." He asked, as he rubbed his back as it was sore from being in the same position for too long. "Tomorrow, sir, I'm afraid your going to have to cope with my dialogue for now sir." Sirce sighed, and although he was annoyed, he knew better than to

direct it at Nove'.

Recently, Sirce, has been feeling the heat in terms of responsibility's being laid upon him first was his training into becoming what was expected of someone of high status, then there was the rehabilitation of the manors landscape after it was left in such disrepair from the previous ground keep, and then appealing to the wit-, considerate wife. Sirce was trying to learn to be careful, he didn't want anymore slip ups. He looked to the corner of the entry way seeing a maid, Elizsha is what he believed her name was staring at him in a prideful disgust, oh and his colleges. He really shouldn't use such a word for they where to separate peoples in the same building the only reason why they had not done anything to harass the

poor man was because Nove' knew how to keep them inline and the madam didn't want any incidents, that as far as Sirce knew he was protected by Meldoa. Sirce assumed the latter would be a running theme no matter who he met.

"Nove', I'm fucking exhausted." Sirce said, he looked at him with the same tired eyes, it really had only been a day but it was not, that they both knew that this farst was only just the beginning and there bodys where only just preparing them for the exhaustion. "Now, master Sirce, watch your tongue." They both exhaled. "Also, master Sirce, do you have the estimate for the redo of the manors lands." Nove' was originally was suppose to take charge of that, due to Sirce being an ape, and having limited knowledge of math, but

Nove' knew better and was aware just by looking at the paper Sirce used to figure out how many plants would go in each box that Sirce was capable of the task. "That's going to take a while Nove'" Nove' nodded. "Just finding an excuse to go into the greenhouse to sit down." Sirce nodded. "I think that is a fine excuse." Sirce said, beginning to walk to its double doors.

"So how serious is this ball anyways." Sirce asked as they walked. "I'm sure you heard that this one is a little more political than the rest." Sirce nodded. "Well the five major families are going to be there, as well as the number of minor families, and middle family but that's typical what really makes it special is that you are not going to be the only human

there." Sirce snapped his head to Nove's, he always thought wolfskin high society was very exclusive he figured that from when he first came here, but why now. "There are part of a collective diplomatic expedition that are going through the continent, the nations are solidifying there independence from us, not that they weren't already, this just drives the point home." Sirce cocked his head. "That's not the point however, what is important is that we want what they have, so making a good first impression is key." Sirce thought for a moment, independence is to act on behalf of oneself, so there send envoys upon there own behalf, okay that's simple. "So that's why this is so important the war caused an expulsion of the wolfskin family's, causing them to lose out

"Yes, but also imagine this, formulate enough trust with the human nations, and you might just end up with a monopoly on diplomacy, who gets to see who and who gets to get what." Sirce nodded. "But wouldn't that mean Junias would have to in some part at as a neutral party." Nove' nodded. "To an extent, depends on the incentives." Sirce was still growing in his logic, he ran a few thought experiments the night before, and even read a few old news papers as he figured they might hold significance, still things seemed to elude him. He wasn't used to politics maybe if he gets the money he can get some books about it but right now he will have to deal with this rough equation he has in his head. Force + means = will and if will >

others_will then you win, so to speak.

Since, unlike most people from where hes from, can see the world through math it was a part of him that he could rely upon when things where uncertain, indeed his university teacher had it beaten into him with speeches and books, as well as conversations, all so he could use this lens reliably. Since began to wonder how he was doing, he understood that he was only doing it because the university got into debt with his parents, but he liked the guy.

"Sounds like you know a lot about this stuff." Since said as they arrived at the double doors. "Spend some time with master Junias you'll eventually pick up a certain portion of the trade." They then made it to the table still remained

in the middle of the greenhouse, with the three chairs that had surrounded the small thing. "And it sounds like I'm going to need to learn a that portion." Nove' nodded. "If you are going to defend yourself yes." Sirce nodded.

They both sat down, reconstituting themselves. "Heh, if only it was break time this would have gone well with some tea and crackers." Nove' said as they both looked into the now sprouting beds. "Sadly, it's not." The feminine voice came from behind, the two looked behind them seeing Meldoa being accompanied by a maid. "Ha, Meldoa I assume your here on business." She sat down the maid standing next to her. "Nove', I need you to start attending to the vault." Nove' seemed to tense up. "So soon, madem they can't possibly

be following through with this at this time, especially with the ball." Meldoa shook her head. "It will be soon, I don't know when but soon, there getting desperate my father underestimated his pressure tactics and there now having the opposite effect." Nove' exhaled. "SO it's war then." She nodded, and arose. "Alright Sirce, lets get to work before work gets to us." Nove' said rising.

Meldoa

Of course things just had to end up this way, Meldoa thought, but she could not blame her father as she knew the situation was balancing a piece of pasta at the end of ones finger. A raid happened last night at least that was what she was told and some of Junias's own men grew angry and went out to draw blood hitting some major depots in other words, a cold war just went a little hot but things could get worse soon. All this could happen before or after the ball so Meldoa, has been business making phone calls and arranging travel for the children to her residence, while the parents go to there own private villas.

Some might see this as a way to easily pick off all the children, and indeed it did come at some risk, but spreading out ones resources came at a great risk, and children are the greatest little risk takers. Besides it is the best to leave them in the care of some one who knows every single one of them well.

"Madam, why are we forced to cater to that ape." Meldoa sighed, she has been dealing with these complaints none stop since she made her intentions clear on bringing in Sirce. "Silence Piltra, it is none of your concern." The maid immediately silenced herself as she followed Meldoa, but it was easy to tell she still harbored resentment over the fact that this ape has climbed the latter essentially overnight and now shes forced to

cater to him, Meldoa scoffed a little to herself, little does she know that this is his prison. She thought, as they approached the office again.

Eric, Tarter, and Vesina should be coming here within the hour, the rest however will be in the following days. She exhaled as she sat at her desk picking up the phone. Honestly why does anyone dream of having this job. She thought as she waited to hear the operators voice. "Yes, operator put me in to the Junias residence line." "Right away miss Meldoa." The operator said, and a few moments later she heard the phone get picked up. "Is everyone moving." Meldoa's father asked. "Yes, there all making preparations as we speak." He exhaled. "This could've gone better, if I could've

foreseen." He paused. "No, no one could've foreseen that." There was then a period of silence. "Sorry Meldoa, it's been a long few hours for me." "I do not doubt that father, is there anything else." "Yes, I'm sending more men up to the residences, yours in particular will be receiving extra support, also for now where holding out what ever happens we don't want to appear as aggressive or the aggressor especially before the ball." Meldoa nodded. "Indeed we don't want the other middle family's feeling threatened and joining in if and when things kick off." Meldoa then looked at the paper work. "Do we have an estimate for how much this going to cost." She heard her father adjust himself. "last time it was a light skirmish, this time I think this

"I'm not so sure they have been rather erratic recently." Junias then followed suit with the silence. "I have considered this possibility, which is why your little endeavor has given so much of a headache." Ouch, Meldoa thought, maybe she could've had her outburst after the ball. "Either way he will serve his purpose at the ball in order for us to gather ape support." She heard him adjust himself, exhaling. "One can only hope." Meldoa gritted her teeth a little. I made my plan, it will work despite him being of common birth.

"Well either way I don't think it has effect there opinions of us that much, at least in comparison to our current circumstance, so as long as we can properly navigate this shit show." Meldoa nodded to

herself, "All right, well I'll get back to my business." "And I'll get back to mine, love you Meldoa." "Love you too." Meldoa placed the phone back onto it's holder and got up from her desk.

"Philtr, prepare for our guests, also fetch Sirce when they arrive they will have to meet him eventually and it will make good practice." Meldoa saw a slight scowl in her face. "Yes, madem." "Piltra." She stopped as she turned around. "If your so much as unprofessional to Sirce, I will see this as a breach of contract and send you out of this manor." She nodded without looking at Meldoa and continued out, people have to make everything fucking difficult shes a good maid just if she could look past this.

Sirce

He stood at the doorway as multiple cars pulled up to the front, watching as an entire convoy of maid, butlers, and guards poured out of every vehicle. And this is only for three kids, he thought as he watched them begin to approach the front, Nove' then came rushing forward standing beside Sirce.

"Goodness how I wish I could just be a middle manager." Sirce looked at Nove'. "Then you'd just be an asshole." He shrugged. "So be it, also the children." He said looking at Sirce with a disapproving glance, Sirce rolled his eyes knowing the drill by heart.

The kids came shuffling in each one of them giving him strange

glares as they walked past. "What is an ape doing here." One said, Sirce paid it no mind, best not to, and once the last child made it safely inside, Meldoa came racing down the steps. "Hello, children." She said, as she stumbled over her heels a little. "I hope the drive wasn't to discomfoting." She was not even halfway down the stairs and two kids tried to make a run for there aunt, there maids however had them hooked from behind by the collars of there cloths.

"Now, now Eric no need to go rushing off, be respectful and patient." One said, as she gave the kid an especially hard yank. Sirce then followed Nove' to the corner of the room where they watched the group of children greet there aunt. "Seems shes good with the kids." Nove' nodded. "Most of there

parents are busy, I mean Meldoa is too, she just somehow makes it all work." Sirce nodded, the scene clawing at his heart as his desire for his own grew.

Now, this witch had up ended his life, put all of his plans on hold, Sirce was never really intending to stay at the factory for every long, in fact he was saving enough money to by a little corner, or at least space for a stall to sell flowers from the family, well they might as well be in the gutter now. He exhaled, then feeling a strong pinch on his back. "Hmm." He muttered looking at Nove' in which he pointed to Meldoa whom was looking at him in a way that told him he should get his ass over there.

Sirce then put on his best face, nothing like a bright smile

to melt all suspicions away or gain some, you never know with people. He then stood next the witch, his wife, whom wrapped her arm around him, and he was forced to do the same, Sirce hid his displeasure and simply endured. "Children I'd like you to meet someone, this is Sirce, and he is my dear fiance." Two of the kids eyes lit up especially the girls. He could not deny that her expression was cute.

"When are you going to get married." She said. Oh god, Sirce thought as he stared at the little thing. "We'll see honey, that's all still a ways away." But there was one child that possed a scowl one that had already asked why he existed here, and this revelation seemed to have only deepened an already deep resentment of him, Meldoa seemed to have taken notice

too, for her expression changed for but a second, but Sirce did not see that.

"Now children, I know that your excited and unruly from such a long drive but right now you should all head to your rooms and get established before supper." Sirce nodded to himself. At least it would get this woman off of me, he thought. The maids then rushed everyone along, the maids that belonged to the house guiding them to there assigned rooms. Meldoa then promptly detaching herself from him. "You should hold me tighter, it will make it more believable." Sirce fought his scowl. "Is there anything else you need me for." "No, also make sure you talk to me as an equal." She then walked away, and headed back up the stairs, well I guess that

just leaves me with the greenhouse not that I'm complaining. "Nove' then came up behind me." "that's going to require you to become familiar with her." Sirce chuckled a little. "Certainly that will be a mountain to climbed." Nove nodded his head. "She's asking way to much from you if you asked me, and it's not like you came in willingly." He exhaled. "Guess we all have to rise to the occasion." He then turned to me. "Oh, sir I've finished preparing the vault is there anything you wish from me." I thought for a moment. "How does a walk through the backyard sound, I still need to see how worse it gets." Nove' smiled. "Lead the way, sir."

The two then wandered the garden right up until lunch, where Nove' was immediately called back

into service, and Sirce was forced to attend, and honestly he was not looking forward to playing this role of loving husband to a bunch of children, he felt dirty putting up a faced, and besides he did not want to confront that one kid whom seemed to understand on a better level the complex relationship of the two species, or well took in all the prejudices of a wolfkin.

Sirce continued through the hallway to the dinning hall, the maid who told him to come, taking charge, Sirce was kinda surprised that she was not throwing her usual glances at him, but he also figured Meldoa had something to do with that they then reached the dinning hall the maid opening the door for him, Sirce continued in finding Meldoa at her usual spot, then continuing over and sitting next to

her. "So how did you two meet." The little girl asked, her ears perking up as she did. "At a ball overseas, it was quite grand." Meldoa answered, there discussion from yesterday then rang through his head. 'Yes a ball, a few letters, I'm surprised she didn't fabricate any, then there was an envoy trip, and then finally a proposal.' Sirce rehearsed everything the best he could, as the last thing he wanted to be was dead weight to this mad woman.

"Ohh, was he a good dancer." Sirce smiled. "No, I'm horrible at it." He responded "Then how did you win her over." Her tail was banging against the seat the sound echoing in the space. "Vesina." Meldoa called, and she immediately calmed herself, the sound of her tail only making subtle thumps as she waited

in anticipation for an answer.

'Shit, I answered honestly and now I don't know what to do.' Sirce was practically frozen, as he pondered what kinda quality would appeal to the witch next to him. "He's very artistic you know." Meldoa said.

"Really, does he draw, paint, ohh, sculpt." Meldoa could not help but smile also. "Garden." The child

twisted her head. "Uh." "You don't see the art in it, surly you must know you can't just mix colors and shapes together haphazardly." 'At least she knows whats she doing.'

Sirce thought as he sighed with relief. "It must be really something then, oh can I see, I saw the greenhouse on the way in."

'well I originally was just going to use that for the vases around the house, so it wasn't going to look like anything shes imagining right

The other child the one whom judged Sirce, on his way in, Tarter, was now staring at him instead of off into space like he was before. He was always rather intelligent for his age picked up on things rather quickly compared to others, but that came at a cost, his childhood. He never wished to be ignorant, but he also wished he could connect with others his age, however same could be said of the adults in other words he is seen as too young by the adults to be given that sense of respect but he feels to grown up to be around people of his age.

But he was not thinking about that, instead his mind was locked onto the couple, he listened to the words they chose, the way they interacted with each other, and the things they discussed. He knew or

could assume that this relationship was not about love he could tell Sirce served some purpose but to whose end he could not tell. It could very well be Meldoa, is the one who gotten into an less then favorable position. Secondly, he could tell Sirce, was thinking about his words, pausing and choosing, sometimes he seemed to catch himself on the verge of saying something and would immediately backtrack and rephrase, it also seems he is trying to get Meldoa to do most of the talking.

He leaned forward a bit whatever is going on he knows he cannot ask about. 'Fricking adults.' he thought, as he broke his attention off for just a moment. "Tarter, are you going to eat." He looked at Meldoa. He found her care to always be annoying but

he did not mind it, she always took good care of everyone, he always wondered how she was able to do it considering how many different litters there where.

He took a spoon full of the shepherds pie and brought it to his mouth, the flavors mixing well with the extensive beef and spices that where added to the simple recipe, he then brought his attention back to the two. He wanted to act as quickly as possible to figure out this charade as it could threaten Meldoa, and likewise the family's future at large, he justed needed to know if it was safe.

Lunched passed on, with Meldoa, asking how the children days went, most of them replied with the usual answers but in truth they deeply enjoyed there outings with Meldoa even if there entire lives where

uprooted at least they could find the time to be with there aunt, whom some secretly called there true mother.

He exhaled, as he thought about all the jealousy and problems he's had to solve because of it, although she will never know. Tarter then continued into his room. 'Honestly, if they just spent more time with there children they wouldn't be calling her there true mother.' He sat at the desk. 'Now Sirce who are you.' They said he was from the continent that had just become independent, that was all they gave him, but he knew those familys where few and far between. He opened a book that contained addresses and names from the region, it was essentially a phone book. He looked and looked and looked, but could not find

anybody with the name he held, it well became noon with a maid knocking at the door, asking if he wanted to visit Meldoa along with the other children in which he refused.

At this point he was confident that this was a nobody, or someone he has not heard before, which is impossible because this book was just put into print a few days ago. He then went downstairs confident he was would be able to confront this Sirce, he stepped through the greenhouses double doors, and locked eyes with the man.

"Sirce, despite my efforts I can't seem to find your family in the contact book." He seemed to pause. "Do you have crest, an address." He watched as the man froze paralyze now that Meldoa was nowhere near him. Just as he

thought this man has no true authority here, if he speaks, he speaks on borrowed will from Meldoa.